

Infants & Children



Slippery Elm
(*Ulmus rubra*)

The following herbs are considered particularly suitable for children, easing symptoms and speeding recovery. Most of the remedies are best given as infusions, and can be given in a bottle. Infusions can be flavored with honey (see *Cautions* right) or maple syrup if necessary, but they are better given unsweetened. The dosages given are for 1–6-year-olds, but they can be adjusted to suit other age groups (see below). Many of the remedies listed in other sections are also suitable for babies and children; herbs that are not appropriate are clearly identified (see p. 299 for dosage requirements before administering any adult remedies).

General Ailments

Infants and children are susceptible to a wide array of ailments.

Digestive upsets that result in diarrhea and constipation can be the result of food intolerance or allergy in infants, especially when foods such as dairy are being introduced into the diet. Other minor digestive upsets due to infection or inflammation can cause loss of appetite.

Colic is a spasm of the gut causing cramping pain in the abdomen. It usually occurs during the first 3 months of life, particularly after feeding in the evening, when the digestion may not be working so well.

Diaper rash occurs when urine, moisture, and irritants in the diaper cause the baby's skin to become red, sore, and damp. It's essential to clean the baby thoroughly at each diaper change. Ensure that cloth diapers are thoroughly rinsed, avoid leaving a wet, chafing diaper on the baby, and remove the diaper completely whenever possible.

Cradle cap is a thick yellow-brown encrustation on the baby's scalp, caused by overactivity of the sebum oil glands.

Headaches, colds, congestion, and chest coughs are common problems in childhood and often respond well to herbal treatment.

Insomnia is a common childhood problem even though children require more sleep than adults and should sleep with ease. Over-excitement, teething, a wet diaper, or being too hot or cold may interfere with sleep patterns. Herbs such as linden will encourage a relaxed night's sleep.

Dosage

The dosages on this page are for 1–6-year-olds. For other ages, adapt the doses as follows:

6–12 months old— $\frac{1}{3}$ dose

7–12 years old— $1\frac{1}{2}$ dose

To adapt remedies from elsewhere in the book for children, see p. 299.

Digestive Upsets, Gas, & Colic

The following infusions are suitable for infants over 6 months. For those under 6 months, the infusions can be taken by breastfeeding mothers.

Herb Ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155)

Remedy Give $\frac{1}{4}$ level tsp of powder with $\frac{1}{4}$ cup (75 ml) of hot water 1–2 times a day.

Herb German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77)

Remedy Make an infusion with 1 level tsp to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Give up to $1\frac{1}{2}$ cups (450 ml) a day.

Herbs Anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248), fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare*, p. 212)

Remedy Make an infusion with 1 level tsp of either of the seeds to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Give up to 1 cup (300 ml) a day.

Herb Slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145)

Remedy Mix 1 tsp of powder with hot water to make a paste, then blend with cold or warm water as required and flavor with honey, cinnamon, or maple syrup. Give up to 50 g powder in doses during the day.

Constipation

Herbs Flaxseed (*Linum usitatissimum*, p. 109), slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145)

Remedy Give 1 tsp of flaxseed or slippery elm with a large glass of water each day.

Diarrhea

Herbs Agrimony (*Agrimonia eupatoria*, p. 162), common plantain (*Plantago major*, p. 251)

Remedy Make an infusion using 15 g of either herb to $\frac{1}{2}$ liter of water and give up to $1\frac{1}{4}$ cup (300 ml) each day.

Diaper Rash & Inflamed Skin Rashes

Herb Chickweed (*Stellaria media*, p. 272)

Remedy Apply ointment 1–2 times a day.

Herb Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Apply ointment or cream to clean, dry

Seek immediate professional advice for:

■ Severe diarrhea or vomiting; a temperature of 102°F (39°C); fever with convulsions; breathing difficulties; unusual drowsiness; high-pitched crying

⚠ **Cautions** Do not give babies under 6 months any medicine without professional advice. Do not give honey to children under 1 year as in rare cases it can cause food poisoning.

skin at each diaper change.

Note For diaper rash, the ointment is best.

Herbs Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73), nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146)

Remedy Make an infusion with 1 level tsp of each herb to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Give $\frac{3}{4}$ – $1\frac{1}{4}$ cup (150–300 ml) a day.

Cradle Cap

Herb Olive (*Olea europaea*, p. 241)

Remedy Apply olive oil to the affected area 1–2 times a day.

Colds, Congestion, & Chest Coughs

Herb Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Make an infusion with 1 level tsp herb to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Give $\frac{2}{3}$ –1 cup a day.

Herbs Elderberry (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132),

pelargonium (*Pelargonium sidoides*, p. 120),

thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Make an infusion with 1 level tsp thyme leaves to $\frac{3}{3}$ cup of water. Give $\frac{2}{3}$ –1 cup a day.

Remedy Give elderberry or pelargonium extract, as recommended by practitioner or supplier.

Earache

Herb Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

Remedy Break open a garlic oil capsule, put 1 drop on a cotton ball, and plug into the ear.

Teething

Herbs German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), slippery elm (*Ulmus rubra*, p. 145)

Remedy Give German chamomile infusion (see *Digestive Upsets*) or make a paste from slippery elm powder and the infusion, and rub on the gums.

Difficulty in Sleeping

Herbs German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277)

Remedy Make an infusion using either herb and give $\frac{3}{4}$ – $1\frac{1}{4}$ cups (150–300 ml) before bedtime.